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The Maasai of Matapato

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Document Type: Book

Original Page: 84

Culture (OWC): [Maasai \(FL12\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: July 1976-September 1977

Coverage Date: Not Specified

Place Coverage: Matapato, Kenya

Section Title(S)

THE MOUNTING TENSION OVER PRIVILEGES • THE NOVICE MORAN AND THE ADJUSTMENT OF FAMILY TIES

The spirit of the occasion appears to be a frolic, almost as if with their wooden earplugs, the novices are once again truant herdboys playing at being moran. The various allusions are to the period when they will leave home and take their mothers to live in the manyata (their warrior village); and their fathers, who are conspicuously absent, are the indirect butt of the joke. If mothers have sexual relations with their own fathers and with the moran friends of their daughters and come under the overbearing protection of their own sons and feed them, then their husbands - the fathers of the moran - are superfluous. In this way the joking in this feast draws attention to the prospective shift in the established order within each family when the omnipotence of the family head as husband and father is undermined. For the duration of the manyata, it is the sons who will control (*a-itore*) their mothers and become the possessors (*ilopeny*) of their huts. Building a manyata is still some way off, but the realignment of family relations that it will entail is already anticipated with relish.

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THE MOUNTING TENSION OVER PRIVILEGES

It is popularly assumed that their forest feasting builds up the novice moran physically and psychologically, so that they are better able to stand up for themselves. The senior moran by this time have started to settle down, but they still dominate the arena of moranhood. This is symbolised by the possession of their privileges: the right to form raiding parties, hunt lions, assert the marks of bravery on their shields, carry dark hafts on their spears, grunt and yelp as moran, dance in any central corral, and play with girls in every sense of the term. It is their privilege to confer these on the  85 next

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age-set at a time of their own choosing. Ideally this is the latest possible moment while strength and initiative still lies with them. At this point, they can claim that they will retrieve the privileges again if the juniors abuse them, and no-one would suggest that they have relinquished them under duress. At any time after this point with their failing strength, however, the initiative shifts away from the seniors and any claim of this kind is patent rhetoric. They can no longer stop the juniors assuming the privileges and proclaiming themselves moran in the fullest sense. Once they can do this, they have taken possession of the arena.

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